▶ TAMIL NADU

THE GODS OF EDUCATION

Should temple funds be used for building colleges? An old debate about state control of temples heats up with political rhetoric in poll-bound Tamil Nadu

By **Kavitha Muralidharan**



ADOBE STOCK

RELIGION FOR RELIGION'S SAKE? The Sri Meenakshi temple in Madurai, Tamil Nadu

CONTROL OVER TEMPLES—and, more to the point, temple funds—has been historically an emotive point of contention between traditionalists and rationalists in the South. The former prefer autonomy for the religious sphere and see any apparent overreach by the latter as a transgression—it's also an easy way to raise public passions. The latest shot across the bow came in a campaign remark by AIADMK leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami (EPS). Speaking during a statewide tour, he accused the ruling DMK of misusing temple funds for purposes unrelated to religion. That has escalated into a wider clash involving electoral strategies, the law, and the legacy of Dravidian politics.

"Even seeing temples irritates the DMK," EPS told crowds in Coimbatore. "They are taking all the temple money and building colleges. People like you, with good hearts, donate into *hundiyals* for temple development. That money goes to the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments (HR&CE) department. They're diverting it. Isn't it unfair? Shouldn't the government fund colleges from its own resources?"

The DMK backlash was sharp and swift. "Even during his time, temple funds were used to inaugurate colleges. The HR&CE Act clearly allows surplus temple funds to be used for educational and charitable purposes," CM M.K. Stalin said, in his first jab. Then he let go of a roundhouse: "From being a dubbed voice of the BJP, EPS has now become its original voice." Deputy CM Udhayanidhi Stalin was no less vitriolic: "EPS has fully transformed into a Sanghi. This is not the voice of the AIADMK; it's the voice of the RSS-BJP."

FIGHT FOR FAITH

There's context to the DMK's charge. For decades, the RSS-BJP has said temples should be administered solely by 'devotees'. The demand was revived at the World Murugan Devotees Conference at Madurai, in June. With BJP leaders in attendance, the event passed a resolution calling for 'liberating' temple affairs from state control. On July 12, the party raked up the issue again, insisting on transparency to prevent "the plunder of temple wealth" and demanding a white paper on the issue. "This talk of building new colleges is nothing but a smokescreen," S.G. Suryah, state secretary of the Tamil Nadu BJP, told INDIA TODAY. "The government's real record is one of neglect; thousands of

Takeaways

- **EPS rakes up the question of whether temple funds should serve non-devotional needs**
- **DMK hits back, painting his stance as 'anti-education'**